

ESPORTS WORLD CUP GROWS, AND SO DOES INDIA

Esports World Cup 2026 will feature a prize money of a **whopping** USD 75 million, a 20 per cent increase from the inaugural edition

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The esports ecosystem has shifted from gaming parlours to indoor, packed arenas. It was one of the most in-demand events at the 2022 Asian Games — a conventional sports event — and is now a USD 2.12 billion market (source: Skyquest).

Esports isn't mere recreation; it's a career avenue. And one of the key driving factors to the success has been building competitive ecosystems.

While titles like DOTA — The International — and Counter-Strike — Major — already had separate tournaments, bringing them under an umbrella has worked wonders for the Esports World Cup (EWC), run by the EWC Foundation.

The inaugural 2024 edition reached 10.5 million people in India alone, according to the Broadcast Audience Research Council (BARC) — despite no Indian participation.

That gave esports clubs in the country a new goal — one that S8UL achieved in 2025, becoming the first Indian club partner at the tournament.

"We see significant positivity in the years to come. Last year, we had our first Indian club, and what was clear to us was that with the inclusion of chess, the passion of Indian gaming fans was nothing as we had ever seen before," Mike McCabe, the Chief Operating Officer of EWCF, says in a select media interaction.

"We are looking at what we can do more from India's perspective.

"It has a positive future. We want to see more rosters go through the qualifications, as we are excited to see

participation from more Indian clubs," he adds.

For India, too, the ecosystem has changed, with the esports industry growing from a USD 33 million to a USD 107 million market (source: Ken Research), and the feather on the cap has been the government's nod.

"In our collaboration with publishers, we saw that the interest in growing in India is very strong," Fabian Scheuermann, Chief Games Officer, EWC, adds.

"Esports for publisher-driven ecosystems is growing, and it will also mean that it can double down with more rosters across different games. I am hopeful that in 2026 and 2027, Indian teams' participation across different titles will grow."

At the global level, the 2026 EWC — scheduled between July 6 and August 23, featuring 24 total games — has expanded its prize pool further, from USD 62.5 million to USD 75 million.

From this pool, USD 39 million has been assigned to the titles, and a further USD 30 million has been set aside for the Club Championship — EWCF's flagship event.

The remaining USD 6 million will be used for club and player awards across the seven-week-long festival. There is a glimpse of India here, too: Cricket, the closest to religion in sports in India.

"We look at it (eCricket titles) as festive (demonstrative) titles, but as a club title, it's not suitable because we don't really have a club versus club professional ecosystem. But that's for now, and as cricket continues to grow as a phenomenon, maybe one can see it in 2028 or 2029," Scheuermann adds.